At the two-day council meet, Modi became a Pied Piper. News cameras followed his every move, party cadres wanted to click selfies with him; every time his name was mentioned in any speech there were loud cheers, and he was given a standing ovation for a third successive win in Gujarat. ‘I hadn’t seen anything like this in the BJP,’ confessed a veteran BJP watcher. ‘The man’s popularity within the rank and file was even greater than Vajpayeeji in his pomp.’ Vajpayee, after all, was seen as a statesman in the Nehruvian mould; Modi was an ideologue who tapped into the BJP’s natural Hindutva moorings. The groundswell of support to anoint him as the party’s leader for the 2014 elections was rising.

Modi spoke on the second day of the meet. The speech was vintage Modi—he was addressing the party faithful, and the political aggression was back as he launched into the Gandhi family and the UPA government. ‘Sacrificing national interest for the interest of one family is the tradition of the Congress,’ thundered Mr Modi, going for the jugular. ‘They appointed a nightwatchman by naming Manmohan Singh as prime minister . . . the prime minister is nothing but a puppet of the Gandhi family.’ The 2000-strong cheering crowd chanted his name repeatedly. A political meet had become a show of strength.

That very day, Sushma Swaraj also spoke. Her speech, too, was powerful but stateswomanlike, as she reflected on the need to topple the UPA government. Her speech was applauded, with L.K. Advani even likening her oratory to Vajpayee. But while the television channels aired Modi’s speech without any advertising breaks (it would become a familiar practice over the next twelve months, causing loss in revenues to news channels!), Sushma Swaraj’s speech was shown only intermittently. In the TRP (television rating point) war, Modi was already the winner.

He also won another battle that day. Who amongst the BJP’s Generation Next would succeed the Vajpayee–Advani duo as the face of the party—the issue had unsettled the BJP ever since Vajpayee had lost the 2004 elections. Vajpayee and Advani had, after all, dominated BJP politics for almost four decades, a unique partnership that was respectful and competitive at the